

NORTHSTAR OUTFITTERS

Shopping & Product Discovery Guide

Product families, variants, availability semantics, pricing guidance, and assisted shopping

CUSTOMER SAFE

Version	3.0
Document owner	Commerce Experience
Last updated	14 September 2026
Purpose	Customer-facing reference for helping shoppers discover and compare products without treating static documentation as live inventory.

Demo environment only. Northstar Outfitters, its customers, products, prices, orders, and commercial terms are fictional and created for SupportOps demonstrations.

Document Control

Audience	Customers, sales/support agents, and AI customer support
Scope	Product categories, product information, variant terminology, availability, pricing semantics, product comparison, and catalog questions
Authority	Authoritative for product-category explanations and shopping guidance. Shopify catalog data is authoritative for live product titles, variants, prices, availability, and sellability.
Review cycle	Quarterly or after a material policy/commerce change
Change control	Material changes require owner review and publication before becoming authoritative knowledge.
Knowledge governance Only documents marked PUBLISHED in SupportOps are authoritative for customer-facing answers. Current Shopify catalog, variant, price, availability, cart, and authenticated order state should be obtained from the approved Shopify MCP capability rather than inferred from static documentation.	

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1. About Northstar Outfitters

Northstar Outfitters is a fictional direct-to-consumer outdoor and everyday mobility brand used in the SupportOps commerce demo. The catalog includes footwear, lightweight apparel, daypacks, hydration accessories, and travel essentials. Product pages are maintained in Shopify and may change more frequently than this document.

Source boundary

Use this guide for stable product guidance. Use Shopify MCP for the current catalog, variant options, current price, active discounts represented in the catalog, and whether a specific variant can currently be purchased.

2. Product Families

Family	Examples in demo catalog	Typical customer intent	Important attributes
Trail footwear	RidgeTrail Pro	Trail running, grip, wet terrain	Size, color, outsole, terrain, fit
Everyday footwear	CityStride Knit	Commuting, casual wear, travel	Size, color, fit, weight
Outerwear	SummitShell Jacket	Rain protection, lightweight shell	Size, color, waterproofing, layering
Pants	TrailFlex Pants	Travel, hiking, everyday mobility	Waist/size, color, stretch, inseam
Bags	Alpine Daypack 22L	Day trips, commute, carry-on organization	Capacity, laptop sleeve, dimensions
Accessories	Transit Bottle 750ml, TrekLite Socks	Hydration and essentials	Capacity, material, size, pack quantity

3. How Product Variants Work

A product can have one or more variants. Footwear commonly varies by size and color; apparel may vary by size and color; accessories may vary by color or capacity. A product being generally available does not guarantee that the customer's preferred variant is available.

Term	Meaning	Example
Product	The parent catalog item	RidgeTrail Pro
Variant	A purchasable combination of options	RidgeTrail Pro / Black / EU 42
Option	A dimension used to define variants	Color or Size
Available	Variant can currently be purchased through the storefront	EU 42 Black is purchasable
Unavailable	Variant cannot currently be purchased	EU 42 Black sold out or disabled

3.1 Variant-specific answering rule

1. Identify the product the customer means.
2. Identify requested color, size, or other variant options.
3. Query Shopify MCP for the current product and variant state.
4. If the requested variant is unavailable, offer only alternatives that are actually returned as available.
5. Do not promise restock dates unless an authoritative source explicitly provides one.

4. Live Availability and Inventory

Inventory changes as orders are placed, fulfilled, cancelled, or adjusted. Static help-center content must never be treated as current stock evidence. Availability shown by the commerce system at the time of the query is the correct source for purchase decisions.

Do not infer inventory

Statements such as “this is one of our core products” or “usually stocked” are not evidence that a specific size/color is currently available.

Customer question	Knowledge contribution	Shopify MCP contribution
Do you sell trail shoes?	Explains product family and use	Returns current matching products
Do you have RidgeTrail Pro in black EU 42?	Explains variant concepts	Returns exact variant and availability
What is the cheapest available trail shoe?	Explains comparison factors	Returns current prices and availability
Is this item discontinued?	Explains that inactive/unavailable are different concepts	Returns current product state; escalate if lifecycle status is ambiguous

5. Price and Sale-Price Behavior

Prices can change due to catalog updates, market settings, promotions, or merchandising decisions. The price shown by the storefront/Shopify integration at the current time should be used for customer-specific purchase questions. Screenshots and old support conversations are historical context only.

- Displayed currency can depend on the active market or storefront configuration.
- A compare-at price may indicate a markdown, but the current purchasable price remains the live catalog price.
- Discount codes are governed by the checkout and promotion rules documented separately.
- Support should not manually promise an old price simply because a previous screenshot shows it.

6. Product Comparison Guidance

Customer priority	Recommend comparing	Avoid overclaiming
Trail performance	Outsole, terrain positioning, fit, upper protection	Do not call a product “best” without a customer need
Daily comfort	Fit, weight, upper construction, intended use	Do not guarantee comfort for every foot shape
Rain protection	Waterproof/water-resistant specification and seam design	Do not describe water-resistant as fully waterproof
Travel	Weight, packability, dimensions, care	Do not guarantee airline acceptance without airline rules
Value	Current price, features, intended use	Do not use stale documented prices

7. Footwear Range

The demo catalog includes trail and everyday footwear. Product names below are illustrative catalog anchors; live Shopify data controls the current option set and availability.

Product	Positioning	Typical fit note	Key use
RidgeTrail Pro	Trail running / mixed terrain	Performance fit; customers between sizes should consult the size guide	Trail runs, light hikes, wet mixed surfaces
CityStride Knit	Everyday lightweight sneaker	Flexible knit upper; everyday fit	Commute, travel, casual use

8. Apparel Range

Product	Positioning	Layering note	Care sensitivity
SummitShell Jacket	Lightweight weather shell	Designed to fit over a base/mid layer	Technical shell care; avoid fabric softener
TrailFlex Pants	Stretch travel/outdoor pants	Regular mobility fit	Wash cool; avoid high heat

9. Bags and Accessories

Product	Key detail	Common question
Alpine Daypack 22L	22-liter daypack with organized carry	Will my laptop fit? Check current product dimensions/specification.
Transit Bottle 750ml	Reusable hydration bottle	Is it dishwasher-safe? Use current product care specification.
TrekLite Socks 3-pack	Performance sock multipack	What size range? Check current variant/size options.

10. Availability and Back-in-Stock Questions

- If a variant is sold out, communicate the current state accurately.
- If the storefront provides a back-in-stock subscription, explain how to use it; do not invent a restock date.
- Offer nearby variants or products only if they meet the customer's stated constraints.
- When a product has no purchasable variants, avoid implying that checkout will work.

11. Bundles and Compatibility

Some products are commonly purchased together, but compatibility must be based on actual dimensions/specifications rather than assumptions. For example, bag laptop compatibility depends on device dimensions, not only screen diagonal.

Scenario	Safe answer pattern
Will bottle fit side pocket?	Compare current product dimensions/capacity specifications; avoid certainty when dimensions are unavailable.
Can jacket layer over fleece?	Use published fit/layering guidance and recommend size selection based on measurements.
Are shoe insoles removable?	Use current product specification. If absent, do not infer.

12. Product Information Quality

When catalog attributes are missing or contradictory, the agent should not fill gaps using model knowledge. Record the exact product/variant and escalate a catalog-content issue when the missing detail materially affects purchase or safety.

Issue	Action
Price differs between support screenshot and Shopify	Use current Shopify price; explain that pricing can change.
Size options differ between old guide and Shopify	Use current Shopify variant options.
Two live Shopify fields conflict	Do not guess; escalate catalog-data mismatch.
Customer asks product attribute absent from all authoritative sources	State that the detail cannot be verified; handoff if purchase decision depends on it.

13. Assisted-Shopping Decision Guide

6. Capture constraints: category, use, size, color, budget, must-have features.
7. Search Shopify catalog using those constraints.
8. Use knowledge to explain stable differences such as fit model or care expectations.
9. Present a small number of matching options and state live price/availability.
10. If no exact result exists, ask which constraint is flexible rather than returning unrelated products.

14. FAQ

Q. Can you guarantee a product will still be in stock later today?

A. No. Availability can change until checkout/order creation is completed.

Q. Can I rely on an old support message for price?

A. No. Current Shopify catalog/checkout pricing is authoritative.

Q. Can you tell me which shoe is best?

A. Support can compare products against your stated use, fit, and budget, but should avoid universal “best” claims.

Q. Why does a product page exist if my size is unavailable?

A. Products can remain active while individual variants are unavailable.

Q. Can the agent suggest alternatives?

A. Yes, but alternatives should be based on currently available Shopify catalog results and the customer's constraints.

15. Revision History

Version	Date	Change
3.0	14 Sep 2026	Reworked catalog-source boundaries for Shopify MCP demo.
2.4	10 Aug 2026	Expanded product comparison and availability guidance.
2.1	15 Jun 2026	Added variant terminology and accessories range.

Appendix A - Catalog Data Interpretation

The commerce agent should interpret Shopify catalog fields conservatively. The same product can have multiple variants, option combinations, market prices, and availability states. Customer-facing answers should preserve those distinctions rather than collapsing the product into a single “in stock/out of stock” label.

Catalog concept	Operational meaning	Customer-facing implication
Product status	Whether the parent catalog product is active/present	Does not prove a requested variant is purchasable
Variant availability	Whether a specific option combination can be purchased	Required for size/color-specific answers
Price	Current variant/product price in active context	Use live value; do not quote legacy documentation
Compare-at price	Reference/markdown field when configured	Can indicate sale, but do not invent percent-off if not provided
Options	Selectable attributes such as Size and Color	Capture exact customer constraints before search
Product description	Merchant-authored product content	Useful for features, but do not override structured fields if conflict exists

Appendix B - Product Search Examples

Customer request	Interpretation	Desired MCP query/result behavior
Black trail shoes under \$120, EU 42	Category=trail footwear; color=black; budget<=120; size=42	Return only current products/variants meeting constraints
I need a waterproof jacket for travel	Category=outerwear; need=weather protection	Search current jackets; use knowledge to distinguish waterproof vs water-resistant
Cheapest bag that fits a laptop	Category=bag; budget priority; compatibility needed	Search bags by price; verify dimensions/specs before compatibility claim
Same shoe as RidgeTrail but cheaper	Anchor product + lower budget	Search comparable footwear; explain differences instead of claiming equivalence

Appendix C - Constraint Relaxation Rules

- Never silently relax size when footwear fit is a hard requirement.
- If exact color is unavailable, ask whether color is flexible before suggesting alternatives.
- Do not exceed a stated hard budget unless clearly labeling the option as above budget and asking permission.
- When there are too many matches, narrow by intended use, fit preference, color, or budget rather than dumping a long catalog list.
- When there are no matches, say which constraints caused the empty result if known.

Appendix D - Detailed Product-Family Notes

Family	Questions to ask	Useful knowledge	Live data still required
Trail footwear	Terrain? distance? size? width preference? budget?	Fit character, care, trail positioning	Available products, size/color variants, current price
Everyday footwear	Commute/travel? size? color? weight preference?	Fit and use positioning	Current variants and price
Shell jackets	Climate? layering? size? color?	Waterproof terminology, layering, care	Current sizes/colors/price
Pants	Use? waist/body measurements? stretch need?	Sizing and care	Current variants/price
Bags	Laptop/device dimensions?	Capacity and compatibility	Current models/specs/price

Family	Questions to ask	Useful knowledge	Live data still required
	capacity? travel use?	method	

Appendix E - Catalog Answer Quality Checklist

11. Restate the customer's key constraints internally before querying.
12. Use live Shopify results for every dynamic attribute.
13. Use this knowledge pack only for stable interpretation and policy.
14. Quote exact product/variant names returned by Shopify.
15. State availability at the time of the query without guaranteeing future stock.
16. Avoid unsupported claims about technical performance.
17. If data conflicts, stop and escalate rather than selecting the more convenient value.